outflanking the central Chinese defences by capturing the ridgeline. The second report, based on an even more detailed study of the situation by the corps commander, was deemed to show the negative outlook of Umrao Singh. Bogey Sen now had the ‘positive’ Dalvi-Prasad attack plan, and the corps commander’s ‘negative’ report. He asked Thapar to immediately sack Lieutenant General Umrao Singh as the GOC of XXXIII Corps.

Through this entire period, the CGS, Kaul, had been missing from Army HQ, and was continuing his holiday in Kashmir. Even though the DMO had dashed off a personal letter asking the CGS to return, both Krishna Menon and Pran Thapar had decided against truncating the Kashmir sojourn and recalling the most powerful man in Army HQ to Delhi.

FROM THE FRYING PAN INTO THE FIRE

Lieutenant General Bijji Kaul’s return to South Block on 3 October coincided with Prime Minister Nehru’s return to India from a trip to various African countries. Krishna Menon had also returned from New York on 30 September. The Bogey Sen-Umrao Singh clash had spilled out into the open by then and the impression in most circles was that the XXXIII Corps Commander was the only obstacle in what was seen as a simple operation. The Intelligence Chief, Mullik, on whose advice Nehru depended heavily, was openly suggesting sacking Umrao Singh and appointing a new corps commander. However, removing Umrao Singh from command at this stage, just as the Chinese were about to be evicted across Thagla would have sent the wrong signals to all the officers and men.

Kaul and Thapar were closeted together for the entire day, with frequent conversations with both Krishna Menon and Nehru. The solution that emerged at the end of the day had the classic stamp of the Menon-Kaul (and Nehru) style of functioning. Kaul had been told that Umrao had failed to deliver and the need of the hour was to have a man at the helm who could, and would, forcefully push the Chinese back across Thagla and the McMahon Line. Since sacking Umrao would be politically incorrect at this stage, Menon suggested a sly plan where he would continue with XXXIII Corps in Shillong, but be made responsible only for Sikkim, Nagaland and East Pakistan, leaving the designated officer who was to replace him in NEFA free to concentrate on the job in hand. Not giving Thapar and Kaul any time to react, Menon quickly added that in his opinion, the designated officer could only be the dynamic and forceful Bijji Kaul.